

THIS ISSUE TRAINS · LEAVING ROOM FOR ERROR

Money and markets

In December 2025 the US Federal Reserve cut rates a third time, to 3.50 to 3.75 percent, after delayed data showed unemployment at 4.6 percent, the highest since 2021. The vote split 9 to 3, the first such division since 2019.

Central banks cut rates for the same reason ships carry pumps: to add buoyancy when things start taking on water. The split tells you honest experts disagreed about how much water there was, and disagreement like that is itself information.

The SCD takeaway: buffers get added before certainty arrives. Whoever waits for proof has waited too long.

Sources: USAGOLD 2025 policy review.

Engineering corner

Aluminum that refuses to sink. Researchers made ordinary aluminum tubes float indefinitely, even punched full of holes, by texturing the surface at a microscopic scale so it permanently traps a layer of air. The safety is not an added system that can fail or be forgotten; it is a property of the surface itself.

The SCD takeaway: safety that lives in the material itself cannot be forgotten in an emergency.

Source: ScienceDaily, January 30, 2026.

Your move

Good designs and good plans assume something will go wrong and leave room for it. Engineers rate a beam for far more load than it should ever see; careful savers keep months of expenses untouched.

This week, on your own: take your next deadline and plan to finish two days early. Watch what those two days absorb that you never predicted.